

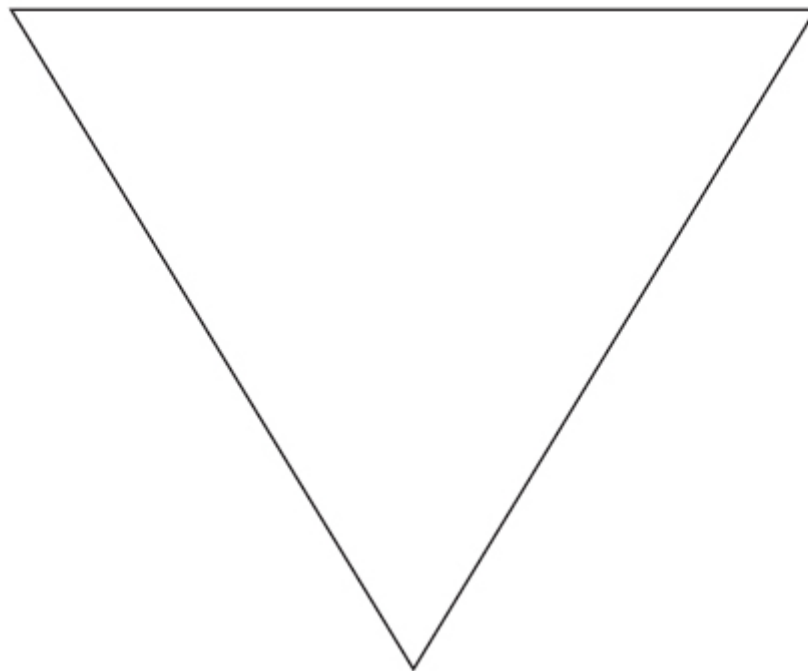
yourself, like a snapshot located someplace in your past, or you may simply feel sadness, pain, or the urge to shrink away or hide in your body. Regardless of how the exile shows up, focus on that. Breathe yourself bigger to make room for the part. Let it know that it's not alone because you're here now. What is it like for the exile to have you nearby? How do you feel toward the part now? If a protector shows up, ask it to step back just enough so you can connect again, just for now.

When you feel open again, ask the exile to share one thing that will help it feel understood in this moment. Take that in. If your protectors feel comfortable, spend more time listening to the exile. Pay attention to any sensation of anxiety in your body. If anxious protectors activate, thank the exile for showing up and ask where it would like to go that's safe and comfortable until you can return. Then write what the exile shared with you on the corresponding box marked *Exiles*.

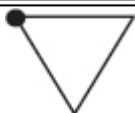
Finally, review the filled-in table as a new map of your parts. Notice each protector team. How do you understand them now? Do they see each other differently? Remind these parts that they don't have to try to fix each other anymore because they can strategize for the good of everyone with you. Point out that you know the exile now, you understand its burdens, and you're here to help. Then send love and compassion to your exile. Thank it for showing up. Appreciate how long it's been waiting for support and how courageous it has been. Let it know that, going forward, you and all these protectors aim to work together to establish safety, and that you will stay in relationship and be available to everyone. No one needs to be alone anymore.

Managers

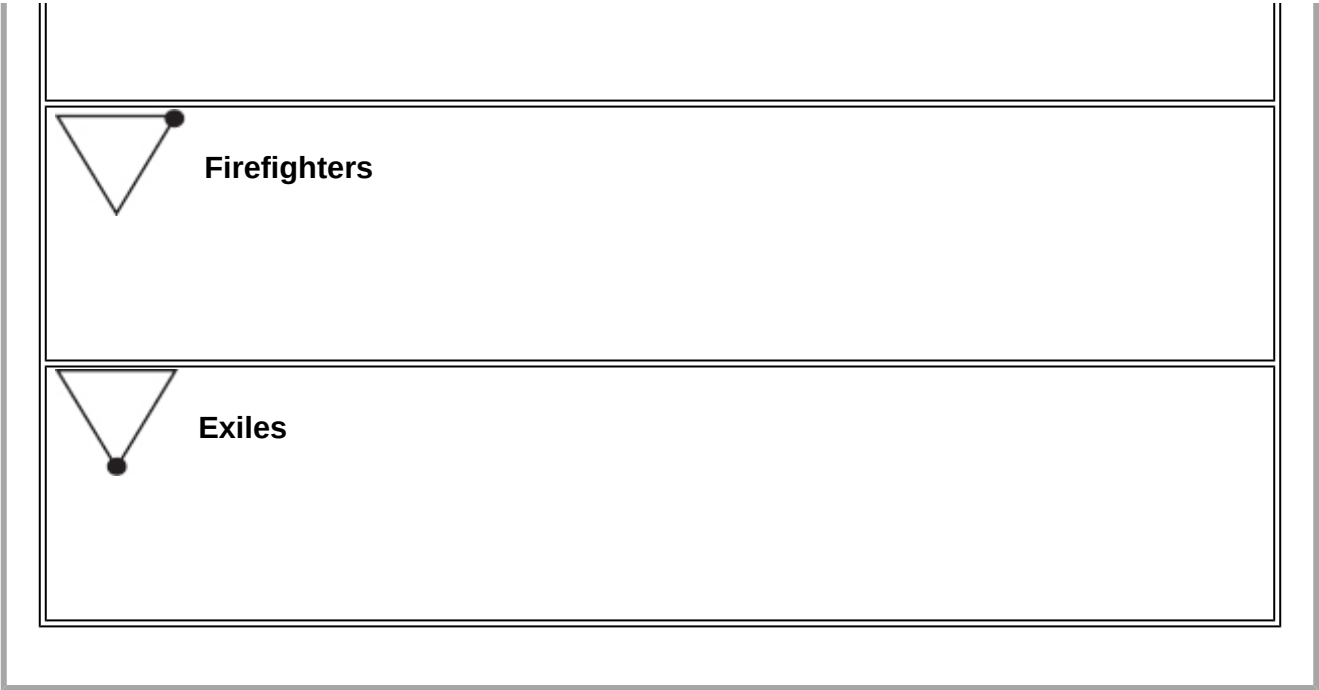
Firefighters



Exiles



Managers



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CALMING THE ADDICTIVE POLARITY

As we've been emphasizing, protective parts in addictive systems are in chronic conflict and have no trusted leader. To calm the addictive polarity, we start by identifying, welcoming, and befriending both the functional managers and the risk-taking firefighters. We help both teams separate from the client's Self and talk about their fears, intentions, and addictive processes. The client hears all this for the first time, understands their divided cravings for control and soothing, and sees how they escalate with each other. The client's Self gets traction by developing strong, clear, responsive connections with each part, which encourages them to keep unblending. When a part unblends, clients feel more accepting of themselves and often experience a greater sense of agency: *Okay! Maybe I can do this now*. Parts who feel connected with the Self are more willing to unblend in the future, both in session and at home.

As ranting managers calm down and firefighters let up on high-risk practices, the mind feels more spacious, and parts trust the Self more. At this phase of treatment, we see clients begin to make different choices on occasion. However, these periods of unblended psychic space also give exiles the opportunity to push for attention, which can cause protectors to double back and panic. To head off the urgency of exiles, we continue to include them in brief *one-way* connections to the Self, reminding them they are not alone and that we are coming with help. We promise that addressing the concerns of tough protectors will help to create more space and safety for them. We ask them not to overwhelm the system, which is an intervention Schwartz discovered early on in his work with exiled parts (Schwartz & Sweezy, 2020).

As the client invites protectors to be direct about their worries, they gradually pivot from acting out to saying no, saying yes, and making requests. If protectors believe therapy is moving too fast, we can slow down. These conversations around speed and need are novel for parts who are used to being disregarded and disempowered. They are often crucial turning points in the client's inner journey.

GETTING TO KNOW FIREFIGHTERS

By the time clients with compulsivity problems walk into our office, they will have tried countless times—sometimes with multiple strategies—to control their drinking, eating, sexual obsessions, or online gambling. Some of their parts will be angry about being shamed, controlled, or judged during bad experiences with previous treatments (Hari, 2015). Others will be fearful of failing again or even ready to die before they tolerate one more humiliation. When an IFS therapist is able to notice these negative assumptions and guide these parts to step back, therapy will feel safe for the client and their parts will engage. A firefighter part might start dropping hints, like complaining that other people think their behavior is getting worse, or a manager might spill the beans more directly. Either way, this information gives us an opportunity to move on from the addiction polarity and review the client's earliest experiments with firefighter behaviors.

We recommend coupling this review with lots of appreciation for a couple of reasons. First, firefighters are remarkably perceptive. They see that the harsh, self-loathing tirades of managers who are trapped in a grim devotion to obligation lead to more loneliness, shamefulness, and despair. Their concerns are legitimate and reality-based. The client's internal environment really is too harsh. In turn, firefighters aim